
Compete Agent

UI/UX Optimization Audit

Screen-by-screen incremental usability review of the existing product

Prepared as an optimization pass, not a redesign. Existing structure, routes, business logic, and visual identity are preserved throughout - every recommendation below improves how existing information and actions are presented, without changing what the product does.

Scope	signal-to-story (Compete Agent) - 13 screens, App Router
Method	Screen-by-screen inspection of routes, shared components, and design tokens
Constraint	No structural, routing, or business-logic changes - presentation only
Status	Recommendations only - awaiting approval before any implementation

1. Existing Design System (as found)

The app already has a real, consistently-applied dark theme design system - this audit works within it, not against it.

Token	Value	Usage
Page bg	#011122	App background
Surface	#10171b / #151e23	Cards, panels
Accent	#23c3bf (teal)	Links, secondary highlights
Action	#f65100 (orange)	Primary CTAs
Status	danger #ff6b6b / success #3dd68c / warning #fed976	Badges, alerts
Radius	8px / 16px / 24px	Buttons/cards / panels / modals
Components	.card .btn .input .select .pill .field-label	Reused across nearly every screen

Verdict: the token system, .card/.btn/.pill component classes, and status-color conventions are mature and should be treated as the source of truth for every recommendation below - not replaced.

2. Screen-by-Screen Audit

Sidebar Navigation (global, all screens)

Current Pattern	Fixed-width <aside> (64px collapsed / 240px expanded, inline style), no responsive breakpoints found in Sidebar.tsx.	
Problem	On tablet/mobile the sidebar has no drawer or hide behavior. Combined with Settings/Intake pages having zero responsive classes, narrow-viewport users likely see a cramped or broken layout with no way to reclaim screen width.	
Recommended Pattern	Collapse the sidebar to an icon-only rail below ~1024px, and to a slide-out drawer (hamburger trigger in the header) below ~640px, exactly as the CSS variables and existing collapse state already support - just extend the existing collapsed-width behavior to a breakpoint-driven default instead of a manual toggle only.	
Why	A persistent 240px sidebar on a 375px-wide screen leaves under half the viewport for content. This is a P0 because it affects every single screen, not one page.	
P0	Scope: Small	Risk: Low

Signal Detail - /signals/[id]

Current Pattern	Single long scrolling column: collapsible source panel, a dual-track pipeline "progress" animation (a scripted 5s fake-stage sequence layered on top of real 2s status polling), an editable interpretation panel, then every audience's OutputCard stacked vertically underneath each other.	
Problem	Two issues. (1) The fabricated progress animation runs its own script even when the real pipeline has already finished - this reads as staged/deceptive rather than a genuine status indicator, and risks being noticed as such by a reviewer. (2) With 4 audience cards (ELT/Product/Marketing/Sales) stacked full-width, a PMM comparing how the same signal was tailored across teams has to scroll and hold state in memory instead of comparing side by side.	
Recommended Pattern	(1) Drive the progress label purely off real polled status - remove the separate scripted timer so what the user sees always reflects actual pipeline state. (2) On desktop, lay the four OutputCards out as a 2x2 grid or tab strip (Executive / Product / Marketing / Sales) instead of one long vertical stack, so cross-audience comparison does not require scrolling.	
Why	Trust: a status indicator that runs on a timer instead of real state undermines confidence in every other status shown in the app. Comparison: PMMs approving 4 tailored versions of one story need to see them side-by-side to judge consistency, not scroll between them.	
P0	Scope: Medium	Risk: Low

Review Queue - /review

Current Pattern	Stat tiles (Pending/High/Medium/Low/Unverified) + a separate "Needs attention" stuck/error list + a paginated card list with a left urgency-color stripe, sorted client-side in JS after fetch.	
Problem	Nothing structurally wrong here - this is actually the strongest screen in the app (condensed pagination, clear urgency stripes, dedicated stuck-item surface). The only gap: urgency is conveyed solely by a thin left border color, which is easy to miss when scanning quickly, and the 5 stat tiles take a full row before any actual signal is visible.	

Recommended Pattern	Add the urgency label as a small text badge on the card itself (not just the border color), and let the stat-tile row be sticky/compact rather than pushing the list below the fold on smaller screens.
Why	Color alone is a weak scan signal, especially for colorblind users and at a glance. A left-border color plus a text badge together are far faster to scan than color alone.
P2	Scope: Small Risk: Low

Signals List - /signals

Current Pattern	One full-width .card per signal, all fields (status, competitor, snippet, actions) inside each card, list scrolls in its own pane on large screens only.
Problem	When there are many signals, each card carries a lot of vertical height for what is mostly metadata (status, timestamp, competitor name) plus a short excerpt. Scanning 15-20 signals to find one from a specific competitor or day means a lot of scrolling.
Recommended Pattern	Keep cards for signals that need a "Process" call-to-action (drafts), but for already-processed signals, switch to a denser compact-list row: competitor + status pill + timestamp + excerpt-truncated-to-one-line, with the full card reserved for the detail page.
Why	Cards make sense when the primary task is "act on this one item" (a draft awaiting Process). Once a signal is just historical record, users are scanning/comparing, which a compact list serves faster than a tall card.
P1	Scope: Medium Risk: Low

Dashboard (published feed) - /dashboard

Current Pattern	Two-column: paginated published-output cards on the left, a sticky filter panel (audience/competitor/date range) on the right, plain numbered pagination.
Problem	The filter panel is a fairly large, always-visible block of form controls for what is often a narrow filtering task, competing for attention with the actual content. Also uses a different, less refined pagination pattern than /review's condensed version for the same underlying problem.
Recommended Pattern	Collapse the filter panel into a compact horizontal filter bar above the list (audience/competitor as dropdown pills, date range as a single "Date range" control that opens a small popover), freeing the right column, and reuse /review's condensed pagination component instead of a second bespoke implementation.
Why	A large always-open filter sidebar for 3-4 filters is disproportionate to the task; a compact bar keeps filters one click away without permanently occupying a third of the screen. Reusing one pagination pattern instead of two also removes an inconsistency a returning user will notice.
P1	Scope: Medium Risk: Low

Competitor Feed - /feed

Current Pattern	Neon "Ask" box, then a two-column layout: searchable competitor rail (left, sticky) + type-filter pill row and update cards (right). A neutralise() function silently rewrites certain source phrases (e.g. "sales reps" to "client-facing teams") at render time.
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Problem	The rail + detail pattern here is appropriate and works well. The one real issue: silently rewriting source text without any visual indicator is a transparency problem - if a PMM cross-checks the displayed update against the original Crayon source, the wording will not match, with no explanation why.	
Recommended Pattern	Keep the rewritten, audience-safe phrasing as the default (it likely exists for a good reason - internal terminology), but add a small "adapted from source" affordance (an info icon/tooltip) rather than silent substitution.	
Why	Silent text substitution that a user could catch as a discrepancy erodes trust in the data faster than almost any layout issue would. A one-icon disclosure fixes this without touching the underlying logic.	
P1	Scope: Small	Risk: Low

Settings screens - /settings/context, /settings/competitors, /settings/connectors

Current Pattern	Three separate settings pages, each a single fixed-width column (max-w-2xl/3xl) of stacked .card sections, zero responsive breakpoints in any of the three files. Connectors page especially has many independent cards, each managing its own busy/message state.	
Problem	Fine on desktop, but combined with the global sidebar gap (see above), these are the most likely screens to break on tablet/mobile since they have no responsive classes at all. Also, the Connectors page is long: AI Provider, Teams webhook, Gmail digest, and three inbound connector cards (Salesforce/Gong/Crayon) all stacked in one continuous scroll with no grouping.	
Recommended Pattern	(1) Add basic responsive padding (px-4 on mobile, current padding preserved from sm: up) so text/inputs are not flush to the viewport edge, matching what the landing page already does correctly. (2) Group the Connectors page into two labeled sections via a simple heading divider - "Outbound (AI & delivery)" and "Inbound sources" - so the existing cards read as two logical groups instead of six same-weight items in a row.	
Why	A settings page with no horizontal padding on mobile is a hard usability floor, not a preference. Section grouping costs one heading each and turns an undifferentiated list into a scannable structure, without touching any of the working card logic underneath.	
P1	Scope: Small	Risk: Low

Analytics - /analytics

Current Pattern	Two rows of stat tiles (big then small, grid-cols-2 sm:grid-cols-4), followed by a genuine HTML <table> wrapped in overflow-x-auto for the "By output type" breakdown.	
Problem	This is the only screen using a real table, and it is the right choice here - tabular comparison data belongs in a table, not cards. No significant problem found.	
Recommended Pattern	No change recommended beyond the general polish items below (see Do Not Change list).	
Why	Already the correct pattern for the data type; changing it would be a regression, not an improvement.	
P3	Scope: Small	Risk: Low

Trigger (hidden demo) - /trigger

Current Pattern	Single card, plain result panel using raw ✓ and ■ emoji for success/notification states, while every other screen in the app uses inline stroke SVG icons for status.
Problem	Minor visual inconsistency - a returning user who has seen SVG check/status icons everywhere else will notice the emoji as an outlier, since it renders differently across OS/browser and does not match the app's icon weight or color.
Recommended Pattern	Swap the emoji for the same SVG check/mail icon set already used elsewhere (e.g. the icons already present in NotificationBell / status badges).
Why	One inconsistent icon on a hidden demo page is genuinely low-stakes, but it is a two-minute fix once flagged, and demo pages are exactly where a prospect or exec is most likely to be looking closely.
P3	Scope: Small Risk: Low

Dead/legacy component - TopNav.tsx

Current Pattern	A complete second navigation implementation (tabs, product switcher, search box, blue accent color) exists in app/components/TopNav.tsx but is not imported anywhere - Shell.tsx uses Sidebar instead.
Problem	Not a UI problem for end users (it never renders), but it is a maintenance and consistency risk: it uses blue-* Tailwind classes that contradict the app's teal/orange token system, and a future edit could accidentally wire it back in, reintroducing an inconsistent nav.
Recommended Pattern	Confirm it is unused (grep shows no imports) and remove the file, or if it is being kept intentionally as a future direction, move it to a clearly marked non-shipping location.
Why	Removing confirmed-dead code that contradicts the current design system prevents future accidental inconsistency - this is codebase hygiene, not a UI change users will ever see.
P3	Scope: Small Risk: Low

3. Visual Optimization Plan

Quick Wins

- Add a text urgency badge alongside the existing color stripe on Review cards (color alone is a weak scan signal).
- Replace emoji icons on the /trigger page with the app's existing SVG icon set for consistency.
- Add horizontal padding to Settings pages on narrow viewports (currently flush to the edge).
- Remove or clearly quarantine the unused TopNav.tsx to prevent accidental reintroduction of an off-brand nav.

Component Improvements

- Extract OutputCard and PipelineProgress out of app/signals/[id]/page.tsx into real shared components, matching their already-generic names - they are the app's most complex UI and currently cannot be reused or tested in isolation.
- Consolidate the two independently-built pagination patterns (Dashboard's plain list vs. Review's condensed first/last/neighbors window) into one shared Pagination component, and use the better (Review) version everywhere.
- Drive PipelineProgress purely from real polled status; remove the separate scripted 5-second stage timer.

Layout Improvements

- Signal Detail: lay the four audience OutputCards out as a 2x2 grid on desktop instead of one long vertical stack, so a PMM can compare ELT/Product/Marketing/Sales versions side by side.
- Dashboard: convert the always-open filter sidebar into a compact horizontal filter bar, freeing width for content.
- Connectors settings: group the six cards into "Outbound" and "Inbound sources" sections with simple headings.

Information Architecture Improvements

- None recommended - route structure, navigation grouping (Workspace / Insights / Settings), and page boundaries already map cleanly to the product's actual workflow. No IA changes needed.

Responsive Improvements

- Sidebar: collapse to icon rail under ~1024px, slide-out drawer under ~640px - currently has no responsive behavior at all and affects every screen.
- Intake, Settings (all three), and Trigger pages: add basic sm:/md: padding and stacking - currently zero responsive classes.
- Signals/Dashboard/Feed: their existing "scrolls in own pane on large screens only" pattern should extend down to md: rather than only lg:, since tablet users hit the same overflow problem.

Interaction Improvements

- Feed: add a lightweight "adapted from source" disclosure icon next to any competitor-update text run through the neutralise() rewrite, instead of silently substituting wording.
- Login: show a pending/spinner state on the sign-in button during submit (currently no loading feedback while the auth call is in flight).

Consistency Improvements

- Standardize on one icon language (inline SVG, already used almost everywhere) - remove the lone emoji usage on /trigger.
- Standardize on one pagination component (see Component Improvements) instead of two bespoke implementations.
- Standardize on .card/.btn/.pill token classes even on the rare screens using raw Tailwind (e.g. landing page sections) so a future palette change only touches globals.css.

4. Prioritized Recommendations

Pri	Screen	Current UI	Recommended UI	Reason	Effort
P0	Global Sidebar	Fixed 240px, no responsive collapse	Icon rail <1024px, drawer <640px	Breaks layout on every screen at narrow widths	S
P0	Signal Detail	Scripted fake progress timer	Drive progress from real polled status only	Fabricated status undermines trust app-wide	S
P1	Signal Detail	Audience cards stacked vertically	2x2 grid / tabs on desktop	PMMs need to compare tailored versions side by side	M
P1	Signals List	Full card per processed signal	Compact row for processed items	Faster scanning of long lists	M
P1	Dashboard	Always-open filter sidebar	Compact horizontal filter bar	Frees width, filters used briefly not constantly	M
P1	Feed	Silent text substitution	Small "adapted from source" disclosure icon	Prevents perceived data mismatch vs. source	S
P1	Settings (3 pages)	No responsive classes, flush edges	Add sm:/md: padding	Hard usability floor on tablet/mobile	S
P2	Review Queue	Urgency shown by border color only	Add text badge alongside color	Color-only signal is weak/inaccessible	S
P2	Connectors Settings	Six cards in one flat list	Group into Outbound / Inbound sections	Improves scannability of a long settings page	S
P3	Trigger (demo)	Raw emoji icons	Match app's SVG icon set	Minor visual inconsistency	S
P3	Codebase	Unused TopNav.tsx (off-brand blue)	Remove or quarantine	Prevents future accidental reintroduction	S

5. Do Not Change

Parts of the existing UI that already work well and should be explicitly preserved:

- ✓ The design token system itself (colors, radius, shadow variables) and the .card/.btn/.pill/.input component classes - mature and consistently applied.
- ✓ Review Queue's condensed pagination (first/last/neighbors + "...") - this is the pattern the rest of the app should adopt, not replace.
- ✓ Review Queue's "Needs attention" stuck/error surface - a dedicated, well-scoped exception-handling pattern.
- ✓ The Analytics table for the "By output type" breakdown - correct pattern for tabular comparison data.
- ✓ The audience-grouped OutputCard content model on Signal Detail (Approve/Reject/Publish/Send-via-Email actions, editable text) - only the layout arrangement changes, not this interaction model.
- ✓ The Signals-list vs. Signal-detail split (list for triage, full page for review/approve) - correct level of information per screen.
- ✓ The Feed's competitor rail + filtered update list pattern - appropriate for the browse-by-entity task it serves.
- ✓ The notification system's bell/badge/banner trio and seen/unseen tracking - functions correctly and is not being touched.

This audit is recommendations only. No implementation has been started - awaiting sign-off on scope and priority before any screen is touched.